

SDG Goal 12

Responsible consumption and production

SDG Target 12.6

Encourage companies, especially large and transnational companies, to adopt sustainable practices and to integrate sustainability information into their reporting cycle

SDG Indicator 12.6.1

Number of companies publishing sustainability reports

Time series

Voluntary sustainability reporting by companies according to the German Sustainability Code (DNK)

1. General information on the time series

- Date of national metadata: December 21, 2025
- National data: <http://sdg-indicators.de/12-6-1/>
- Definition: The time series show the number of sustainability reports voluntarily submitted by companies not subject to reporting requirements in accordance with the German Sustainability Code (DNK).
- Disaggregation: Not available.

2. Comparability with the UN metadata

- Date of UN metadata: Juli 2024
- UN metadata: <https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/metadata/files/Metadata-12-06-01.pdf>
- The time series is not compliant with the UN metadata, but provides additional information. It does not show all companies that publish sustainability reports, but only those that submit sustainability reports in accordance with the DNK.

3. Data description

- The German Sustainability Code (DNK) was originally designed as an independent reporting standard, offering companies the opportunity to make their sustainable practices transparent and comparable with other companies. It was also intended to help align investment and purchasing decisions with sustainability criteria. Due to developments at the European level, the DNK has evolved into a support tool for implementing the European reporting standards. Since 2017, certain companies in Germany have been legally required to produce sustainability reports. This obligation arises from the European CSR Directive (Corporate Social Responsibility) and its national implementation through the CSR Directive Implementation Act (CSR-RUG). The directive sets both formal and content-related requirements and defines which companies are subject to reporting.

As part of the European Green Deal, the directive was revised in 2022 – now called the Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD) – with a phased expansion of the reporting obligations and the number of companies affected starting from 2025. However, at the time of this publication, the planned extension of mandatory sustainability reporting is still under discussion by European institutions and may be revised or softened. On 26 February 2025, the European Commission presented the so-called Sustainability Omnibus Package, which includes, among other things, a

limitation of the CSRD's scope. At the same time, the European Commission announced that it would introduce a separate standard in 2025 for voluntary sustainability reporting by companies – the Voluntary SME Standard (VSME). This standard is aimed at companies that are not subject to CSRD reporting requirements themselves but need to meet information demands from business partners within value chains or from capital markets.

The indicator for voluntary sustainability reporting captures the number of such companies that are not yet CSRD-reporting entities but have submitted sustainability reports to the DNK. Restricting the indicator to DNK submissions ensures transparent data availability and avoids mixing or double-counting among reporting standards. However, this limitation also means the indicator's significance may be constrained, as it only considers one of several possible standards, even though others may serve a similar purpose. It should also be noted that the number of DNK reports submitted does not provide a direct measure of the actual extent of sustainable business practices in German companies but merely reflects the quantitative scope of sustainability reporting under the DNK. Large companies with corresponding mandatory reporting obligations are not included. The voluntarily submitted reports from the remaining companies are counted unweighted in the indicator, regardless of their size, economic sector, or potential impact of their sustainability activities.

4. Access to data source

- Database on the German Sustainability Code:
<https://www.deutscher-nachhaltigkeitskodex.de/en/view-reports/view-dnk-declarations/>

5. Metadata on source data

- Not available.

6. Timeliness and frequency

- Timeliness: Not applicable.
- Frequency: Annual

7. Calculation method

- Unit of measurement: Number
- Calculation: Not applicable.